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New Mass. laws include a boost for parents, kids

Tax credit is enhanced, and requirement to pass MCAS for diploma dropped

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

With the dawn of a new year, Massachusetts residents could see more money in their pockets, more clarity from prospective employers about salaries for open jobs, and circus acts free of elephants and other exotic animals.

A raft of laws took effect Wednesday and beyond in 2025, promising to reshape everything from what people and businesses pay in taxes to how students earn their high school diplomas. New Year's Day also marked the start of a new legislative session, when lawmakers will push even more changes into law in the months and years to come.

Here are the new laws to watch — and, in one case, one that's ending before it really even started.

Tax changes

Parents of children, as well as caretakers for disabled adults or seniors, will soon fully realize an enhanced tax credit lawmakers passed in the fall of 2023 as part of a \$1 billion tax package.

Billed at the time as the country's most generous universal child and dependent tax credit, the law bumped what taxpayers could claim per dependent last tax season from \$180 to \$310. In 2025, they'll be able to claim \$440 per dependent

► **Leaders of the Legislature vow more transparency, efficiency. B1.**

NEW LAWS, Page B4

Energy program aims to help landlords make green upgrades

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

A few months back, Frank Hays found himself in what he calls a "landlord's plumbing nightmare." At both of the rental properties he owns in Worcester, and even at his own home in Framingham, things just kept going wrong. Water heaters? Busted. Heating system? Down. Appliances? Shot.

"I had more things go wrong in two months than I had in six years," he said.

Being an eco-minded kind of guy, and in need of replacements for the broken units, Hays turned to Mass Save, the state's utility-run energy efficiency program, for assistance with new equipment that would be more durable, highly efficient, and good for the planet. But even with the help from incentives, his out-of-pocket costs were still too high, while any savings on utility costs would be realized by his tenants, not him.

Ultimately, instead of heat pump water heaters and other climate-friendly appliances, he opted to replace his broken equipment with what he'd had previously.

His is an experience many landlords in Massachusetts can relate to, and the reason people living in rentals — who make up more than one-third of households in the state — have been largely left

MASS SAVE, Page A10



MATTHEW HINTON/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

The rented white truck slammed into a crowd on Bourbon Street in the French Quarter. Steel bollards were not engaged.

'Something out of a horror movie'

At least 15 dead in what officials call a terror attack by driver in New Orleans



GERALD HERBERT/ASSOCIATED PRESS

The suspect, who was killed in a shootout with police, was identified as Shamsud-Din Bahar Jabbar, a US citizen and Army veteran. **A6.**

By Jenna Russell, Keith Bradsher, Devlin Barrett, and Emily Cochrane

NEW YORK TIMES

It was just after 3 a.m. on Wednesday, and while much of the country had already gone to bed after toasting the new year, the party was still going — as it usually does — on Bourbon Street in New Orleans.

Then came the sound of a white pickup truck, accelerating. In an instant, the city's best-known, most popular public space was transformed into a scene of death and terror.

"We heard him punch the gas and then the impact and then the screams," said Kimberly Stricklin, of Mobile, Ala., who watched with her husband as the truck careened onto Bourbon Street and slammed into the crowd. "It just took a moment to register, it was just so frightening — it was like something out of a horror movie."

Stricklin said she was haunted by the memory of the sounds one victim had made. "I can't get over that girl's screams," she said.

Described by federal authorities as a deliberate act of terror, the attack killed at least 15 people, wounded about three dozen others, and left New Orleans, a city of

NEW ORLEANS, Page A6

Overworked, underpaid, and unheard, they say, more doctors push to unionize

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

When Dr. Zoe Tseng explains why she decided to help start a union of primary care physicians at Mass General Brigham — and join a wave of doctors organizing nationwide — she recounts what happened in 2023 at the Newton medical practice where she had worked for a decade.

On a Friday afternoon in July, a handful of administrators from

Brigham and Women's Hospital gathered the practice's roughly 35

► **Nurses licensed elsewhere will soon be able to work here. D1.**

employees at the clinic to deliver bad news.

The hospital was going to close the clinic as part of cost-saving efforts, Tseng recalled. The six doctors and two physician assistants would be transferred to other practices.

The remaining employees would be offered jobs elsewhere at Brigham, one of MGB's two flagship hospitals.

Tseng and her co-workers were stunned, she said. Several began to cry. Tseng worried about her patients, especially those who lived near the practice. Would they follow her wherever she landed?

"We were all essentially blindsided," said Tseng, 40, who moved to a Brigham clinic in Longwood after

DOCTORS, Page A7

Antisemitic hate crimes reached an eight-year high in Massachusetts, leaving Jewish communities rattled. B1.

The flow of natural gas through a major pipeline from Russia to Europe was cut off after Ukraine refused to renew a prewar agreement. A3.

A volcanic eruption at Yellowstone National Park is unlikely, according to scientists using advanced techniques. A2.

Hiawatha Bray takes a look at some smartphones and computers with built-in AI. Do they work? Sometimes. D1.

It's the right time of year for sports predictions, and Chad Finn has 10 of them for the Boston teams. C1.



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

HERE COMES THE TIDE — The L Street Brownies' annual New Year's jump into icy Dorchester Bay always attracts hundreds, but Christina Nardone and Matthew McConnell went further, getting married before wading in. **B1.**

Whether MAGA or not, everything's red all over

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

President-elect Donald Trump may have dibs on the slogan "Make America Great Again," but "Make America Glamorous Again" — that's the promise of a new lipstick called MAGA Red No. 47. At \$85, it comes in a collectible package and even has its own jingle: "Lipstick shade so bold and bright/No. 47 feels so right . . . Make America Glamorous Again, with a little splash of red."

The limited-edition lipstick is the brainchild of Glenn Dayap and Caroline Lorenzo, a married couple who live in Fullerton, Calif., and describe themselves as "Filipino American entrepreneurs." They saw a gap in the MAGA market —

cosmetics — and decided to capitalize on it. "While there were products [for] almost every niche," Lorenzo said, "none of them catered specifically to women in the MAGA movement who wanted to express pride and patriotism." As for the jingle on their website, it was written — and sung — by AI.

The pair, both registered nurses, own three home health, hospice, and caregiving companies. They also run Kreizi Beauty, the predecessor to their newest business, GoRed Cosmetics. "That's the opportunity we have here in America, to achieve anything you want," said Dayap.

In many ways, it's a quintessentially American tale of opportunity

RED, Page A7



A fair shake

Thursday: Sunny but windy. High 42-47. Low 29-34.

Friday: Colder than it's been. High 35-40. Low 23-28.

Sunrise: 7:13 Sunset: 4:23

Weather and Comics, D5-6. Obituaries, C9.

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Suggested retail price \$4.00

